

HOW THEY MEASURE UP



RAFALE



STRENGTHS Advanced fifth-generation aircraft with stealth features

WEAKNESSES Poor export orders could jeopardise future development



TYPHOON



STRENGTHS Futuristic fighter aircraft with advanced features

WEAKNESSES Expensive; more in the league of IAF'S existing Su-30MKI



MiG-35



STRENGTHS Compatible with IAF's existing MiG-29 fleet

WEAKNESSES Russia's track record of poor after-sales support and service



F-16



STRENGTHS Versatile medium fighter; has record global sales to its credit

WEAKNESSES Is being sold to Pakistan; prospects of upgradation are bleak



F/A-18



STRENGTHS Fighter-attack; formidable radar; room for upgradation

WEAKNESSES Due to its high cost, it may not fit in India's MMRCA budget



GRIPEN



STRENGTHS Capable fourth-generation light fighter

WEAKNESSES Poor export orders could jeopardise future development

terming the world's largest military aircraft contract in 15 years, historic. "This is unlike any other defence deal. It will not only decide the future of combat airpower in the subcontinent, but will also be a benchmark for further access to weapons and equipment," says Air Commodore (retired) Jasjit Singh, director, Centre for Air Power Studies.

In the past, when India entered into such contracts, it ended up producing aircraft without the vital design data. Keen not to repeat the mistake, the Ministry of Defence (MOD) says it will ensure there is transfer of technology this time. "We plan to leverage our purchasing power to develop our defence industry while making sure that we can conduct upgrades, field new platforms and have reliable product support," says a senior MOD official. The agreement will also include a 50 per cent offset clause, according to which the foreign firm will have to plough back half of the contractual

amount, or about \$5 billion (Rs 20,000 crore), to buy components from the Indian market. "The programme will create jobs and build manufacturing capacity in India. The national objective will be served," says Ashok K. Baweja, chairman, HAL.

The firm that bags the contract will get a substantial foothold in India's defence industry for the life term of the aircraft. "We view the MMRCA as a cornerstone of our potential business strategy for India. This gives us an opportunity to become part of the Indian defence fabric, provide a solution for IAF's warfighting abilities, and partner with Indian industries," says Chris Chadwick, vice-president, Global Strike Solutions, Boeing Integrated Defence Systems.

Like most defence deals, the MMRCA deal has long been in the pipeline. Alarm bells started ringing in 1999, when IAF had to start junking the MiG-21s it had bought way back in the

1960s and '70s. It first proposed buying 126 Mirage 2000 medium-range multi-role fighters from France. To be built in India, the Mirages were not only meant to tide over the delay in the induction of the indigenous Tejas, but would also have given IAF multi-role aircraft to plug the gap between LCA like the MiG-21 and the heavier Su-30MKI. The proposal was cleared by NDA in 2001, but scrapped by the UPA Government, which called for fresh international tenders and competitive bidding.

The delay may prove to be costly. Two-thirds of the IAF fleet is over 20 years old and if its squadrons continue to shrink, 126 MMRCA won't be enough to meet the shortfall. India may well decide to produce over 200 aircraft. "We needed 126 more aircraft a decade ago. This number needs to be re-examined in the light of the falling strength of our squadrons," says Krishnaswamy.

The entry of two US giants, Boeing